

How Social Media Algorithms Shape Creative Identity Among Small Independent Visual Artists

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Abstract

This paper investigates the impact of recommendation systems on the creative identity of small independent visual artists. While existing literature reveals that recommendation systems have the power to act as gatekeepers of cultural content, to create uncertainty among platform workers, and to require certain skills from those who create content, there has been less attention paid to how small visual artists discuss such systems as a problem related to their art and creative identity. Through qualitative discourse analysis of six texts published by small visual artists and three texts published by social media platforms between 2020 and 2025, this study investigates the experiences of small artists who interact with social media recommendation systems. These texts range from artist essays and articles discussing art to official explanations of the ranking systems of platforms like Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube. The results of this analysis reveal that the small artists that were studied did not discuss the recommendation systems of social media platforms as only a topic related to the distribution of their art. Instead, their discussions of recommendation systems indicated that they often experienced such systems as invisible gatekeepers to audiences, which created instability in their relationship with their audiences and their responsibilities to create content that was small artists could publish and view. Furthermore, their discussions of their experiences with recommendation systems indicates that their concept of artistic creativity is, at the very least, defensive in relation to the invisibility of their art that is enabled through recommendation systems. These findings contribute to the existing literature on both the impacts of recommendation systems on creators and small visual artists, suggesting that

efforts should be made towards treating audience building as an aspect of artistic development rather than as a private responsibility of the artists themselves.

Introduction

For small visual artists, social media promised to be a more democratic form of the art world. Instead of having to gain the approval of various art world institutions before they could exhibit their work, painters, illustrators, photographers, tattoo artists, and digital artists had a platform to exhibit their art. For small visual artists, this was important due to the relationship between exposure and sales. If the audience does not get to view the artist's work, then there is no way for that audience to respond to the art or the artist itself. For those without the support that the art world typically offers to popular artists, social media offers a variety of spaces for them to exhibit themselves.

However, the digital art world has become less direct. Instead of being able to simply publish art into an audience that they have created themselves, digital artists must contend with the filtering power of social media algorithms. What gets published to an audience can change from week to week. Some works may garner significant views while others may receive very little. Additionally, artists are often required to rely upon metrics to gauge the success of their art projects rather than the underlying and often invisible social media platforms that make their art possible to view.

Furthermore, many artists use these platforms to exhibit themselves and their work to the public as a means of presenting themselves and their creative identities. Therefore, the invisible gatekeepers of social media have a powerful influence upon the identities of these visual artists. While the gatekeepers may be invisible to the public, they are still present in the creation of these

platforms as a means of making sure that only the most popular artists receive the most views on their art projects.

Using these definitions, the question that will be explored in this research project is: How do social media algorithms impact the creative identity of small independent visual artists? The creative identity can be considered the artist's understanding and presentation of their role as a creator. Small independent visual artists are those who do not receive the same level of support from the art world and who rely upon digital platforms to exhibit their art. Through analyzing these artists' presentations of social media algorithms, it is possible to understand the impact that algorithms have upon the lives of these creators.

Literature Review

Of the vast array of cultures that could be studied in order to determine in what ways they exhibit their relationship with technology, one aspect of our society's culture that has been considered in some ways by research on a variety of algorithms. Authors like Gillespie (2014), Beer (2017), and Kitchin (2017) have all published research that aids in the support of the first assumption in this paper: that algorithms, like social media algorithms, are cultural actors. Additionally, authors like Bucher (2017), Eslami et al. (2015), and DeVito, Gergle, and Birnholtz (2017) have each performed studies on those within social media platforms and their reactions to or understanding of the algorithms that direct their user experiences; these type of studies help to contextualize the second assumption of this paper: that creative artists are aware of the impact of these algorithms, and make creative decisions on their platforms as a result. A final group of authors that aids in the validation of the paper's assumptions are Nieborg and Poell (2018), Poell, Nieborg, and van Dijck (2019), Duffy (2017, 2020), Cotter (2019), Bishop (2019), and Klawitter and Hargittai (2018). These authors have performed studies that are reflective of the third

assumption: that artists feel pressure from social media to perform upon its platforms. Related to this second assumption, scholars such as Abidin (2016), Baym (2018), Cunningham and Craig (2019), and Caplan and Gillespie (2020) also have completed studies that reflect the duties that are expected to be fulfilled for those who desire to perform well upon social media platforms. Finally, studies by authors like Noble (2018), Striphas (2015), Seaver (2017), among others, have helped to contextualize the overall culture in which creative artists perform upon social media platforms. While these authors do not directly discuss visual artists themselves, they have laid the foundation upon which this type of research can be built; their efforts have become somewhat foundational for this research project. Thus, an area that has often been studied regarding social media creative artists is in relation to influencers or YouTubers, or other types of individuals who rely upon social media as their industry. Visual artists, unless those artists are also users upon which social media platforms capitalize, are rarely considered in these types of studies. It is in this gap in research that this topic was chosen; the observation that many visual artists are also aware of and impacted by these platform algorithms inspires a desire to perform this type of targeted research into those visual artists as an additional culture affected by technological cultural actors.

Related to the idea of algorithms as cultural actors is the idea that artists are impacted by those algorithms. Studies by authors like Kellogg, Valentine, and Christin (2020), for example, have examined how workers for various companies react to and feel controlled by the perceived ‘demands’ of technology systems. Relatedly, algorithms may appear to have the same type of controlling ‘demand’ towards artists; not fulfilling those demands would seemingly mean being excluded from access to vast numbers of platform viewers. However, unlike in the examples from these other studies where individuals may feel pressure to merely survive as a company or

online entity, artists both apply their critiques and feelings of judgement upon themselves in relation to these platforms. Thus, further study on these feelings by artists is important to understand why these algorithms create such reactions within those artists; how can algorithmic societal systems create such personal reactions by those who use these cultural technologies?

Methodology

The qualitative discourse analysis was appropriate for answering the research question about how artists discuss algorithms on social media platforms. Therefore, discourse analysis was utilized for this project to determine how artists within various communities discuss the concept of algorithms and their impact upon visual art and artists.

The texts were collected through targeted searches on the web between April 28 and May 1, 2026 using terms like “Instagram algorithm artists,” “Instagram dead for artists,” “independent artists social media algorithm,” “artists algorithm reach collapse,” “algorithm anxiety artists,” and “Instagram for artists do's and don'ts.” Each of these texts needed to focus upon visual artists, discuss social media algorithms, be accessible to the public, and discuss their artistic work with those criteria. In addition to these texts by artists, three official texts from social media platforms (Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube) were also collected and utilized to provide a comparison between the two concepts. More specific comments, discussions outside of the platforms’ official channels, and paywalled content was excluded from this research for both ethical and practical reasons.

The results of this research included six texts written by and for artists, and three texts from the social media platforms explaining their algorithms. The texts written by the artists included discussions from Hyperlux Magazine, GinAngieLa.com on social media’s “Social Art Dilemma,” two blog posts from Saturno discussing Instagram and moving away from the social

media platform, a post from Sara Leger discussing whether Instagram is worth using as artists, and a blog post from Gallery 4% that provides advice to artists considering Instagram as a social media platform for their art. The explanations from the social media platforms included Instagram's description of the ranking of posts on the social media platform, an explanation from TikTok of its "For You" page recommendation system, and YouTube's help page that explains the platform's recommendation system for videos on the platform. These two groups of texts were selected in order to provide a more comprehensive discussion on the topic while still remaining focused upon the research question.

Table 1

Corpus Used for Discourse Analysis

Source	Type	Use in analysis
Kahn (2025)	Artist-facing article	Reach collapse, content demands, burnout, alternatives
GinAngieLa.com (2024)	Artist essay	Account status, recommendation limits, paid boosts
Saturno (2024a)	Artist blog post	Paid visibility, product posts, independent artist survival
Saturno (2024b)	Artist blog post	Website/newsletter as response to Instagram dependence
Leger (n.d.)	Artist studio blog	Authenticity, local networks, rejection of spectacle
Ganguly (2025)	Artist advice article	Process content, Stories, algorithm anxiety
Mosseri (2023)	Platform explainer	Instagram ranking across Feed, Stories, Explore, Reels
TikTok (2020)	Platform explainer	For You feed signals and personalization
YouTube Help (n.d.)	Platform explainer	Recommendation signals and user feedback

The unit of analysis was meaning units, which were defined as the sentences or short paragraphs within the texts that made a specific claim regarding the topics of analysis. Each of the texts was read by the researcher, and each of the meaning units related to the research question were highlighted. During the first pass in coding the texts, codes were created that described the concept of each highlighted meaning unit. These codes included terms like reach collapse,

audience instability, format pressure, paid visibility, emotional strain, authenticity, platform explanation, and exit strategy. During the second pass in comparing the codes created during the first pass, the codes were grouped into three main categories. This two-pass method of coding and categorizing the texts is recommended by Braun and Clarke (2006) in their recommendation that qualitative themes should be developed by moving from coded patterns to interpretive themes. The process of developing these themes was utilized to increase the trustworthiness of the research by explaining the formation of each theme, ensuring that each theme was present in multiple texts, and examining for disconfirming evidence, even within the advice texts for Instagram artists. Furthermore, such an approach to theme development was recommended by Nowell et al. (2017).

This methodology has some limitations in relation to the research question. The research does not attempt to represent all Instagram artists, nor does it attempt to measure the reach of Instagram accounts. The texts were public texts with persuasive elements, as they were written either to provide advice to Instagram artists, to criticize Instagram itself, or to explain the ranking of Instagram posts. Thus, these findings only apply to the analysis of discourse among Instagram artists, and do not make any claims regarding representative artists. Despite these limitations, the discourse among these groups of artists is still a means of gaining valuable insights into the way in which those artists are making sense of the platform and its algorithms.

The research was ethical in that all texts utilized were publicly available texts written for broad audiences. No private texts, usernames of Instagram artists from the comment sections of their Instagram posts, or other personally identifiable nonconsented data were collected. Furthermore, the research utilized the original texts from the authors in most cases, except for in instances in which brief quotations from the authors were essential to the interpretation of certain

concepts by those authors. However, the intention of this research is not to reveal the individual texts or artists, but only the general pattern of discourse among the artist communities.

Findings and Discussion

The analysis produced three main findings. First, artist-facing texts describe algorithms as systems that make an already-built audience unstable. Second, they describe visibility as a new form of labor that competes with art-making. Third, they show that artists respond through defensive creativity, a stance in which authenticity is protected against the threat of invisibility. These findings extend the literature on algorithmic precarity by showing that small visual artists experience platform uncertainty not only as income instability but also as a challenge to creative identity.

Finding 1: Audience becomes unstable even after it is built. In traditional artistic gatekeeping, an artist may struggle to enter a gallery, school, magazine, or market. In the artist-facing texts, the struggle is different. The audience may already exist, but the platform can make that audience unreachable. Saturno (2024a) gives the clearest example: a painting reel could receive thousands of likes and tens of thousands of views, while a reel that directed viewers to a product in the artist's store dropped sharply. The important point is not only the numerical difference. It is the interpretation of the difference. The artist reads the lower reach as evidence that the platform separates creative display from commercial survival. Art can be visible as content, but the artist's attempt to sell the work becomes less visible.

Hyperlux Magazine presents a similar pattern at a larger scale. Kahn (2025) describes artists building audiences over years and then seeing posts reach only a tiny fraction of those followers. This discourse turns follower count into an unreliable symbol. A follower is no longer proof of access to a viewer. Instead, the artist owns a number that the platform may or may not activate.

This finding connects to Eslami et al. (2015), who show that users can misread missing content as a social choice rather than an algorithmic result. For artists, that ambiguity can become emotionally heavier because a low-performing post may feel like rejection of the artwork itself. The official platform texts help explain why this happens without fully resolving the artists' concern. Instagram states that it does not use one single algorithm but multiple ranking systems for Feed, Stories, Explore, Reels, and Search (Mosseri, 2023). TikTok describes the For You feed as a personalized ranking system based on interactions, video information, and settings (TikTok, 2020). YouTube explains recommendations through watch history, likes, dislikes, subscriptions, and other signals (YouTube Help, n.d.). These explanations are more transparent than silence, but they still describe visibility from the viewer side. They explain why a viewer might receive content, not how an artist should understand the loss of access to followers. The gap between platform explanation and artist experience is where anxiety forms.

Finding 2: Visibility becomes labor that competes with art-making. Across the artist-facing texts, algorithms are described as demanding constant maintenance. Hyperlux calls this a 'content creation trap' (Kahn, 2025). GinAngieLa.com (2024) describes pressure to post frequently, use new features, monitor account status, and respond to platform incentives. Gallery 4% (Ganguly, 2025) frames Instagram as a space where artists should show process, use Stories, engage like humans, use hashtags, craft bios, and avoid obsessing over the algorithm. This advice is supportive, but it also reveals how much extra work is now attached to being seen.

This finding aligns with Abidin's (2016) visibility labor and Cotter's (2019) visibility game. The artist is not simply asked to make a painting or digital image. The artist is asked to make the work, document the process, edit the documentation, select a format, choose captions, test hashtags, encourage comments, answer messages, post at the right time, and then interpret the

results. In this sense, visibility becomes a second studio. The labor is creative, emotional, and technical at once.

The artist-facing texts show that this labor changes creative time. Saturno (2024b) contrasts the slow time of art with the quick reward structure of social feeds, arguing that art requires attention while platforms encourage rapid scrolling. Leger (n.d.) makes a similar distinction by rejecting the idea that an artist should make herself a spectacle for the sake of reach. These statements are not only complaints about workload. They defend a different time scale for art. A painting may take weeks; a post may live for days or hours. The platform values the repeatable event of posting, while the artist values the slower process of making.

Finding 3: Algorithms pressure artists toward format translation and aesthetic narrowing. A repeated theme in the corpus is that the work most valued by the platform is not always the work most valued by the artist. Hyperlux argues that subtle or complex artworks can lose attention on small screens, while brighter, simpler, or more immediately legible images perform better (Kahn, 2025). Gallery 4% advises artists not to treat Instagram like a quiet gallery wall, but like a conversation space with process, polls, Stories, and personality (Ganguly, 2025). Instagram and TikTok's own explanations also emphasize ranking signals produced by user interaction, such as watching, sharing, liking, commenting, and following (Mosseri, 2023; TikTok, 2020). The result is a translation pressure: art must become content that can trigger measurable interaction quickly. Translation is not automatically negative. Many artists enjoy showing process, telling stories, or making short videos. However, the discourse shows that translation becomes harmful when artists feel they must redesign their artistic presence around what is ranked. This finding extends Nieborg and Poell's (2018) theory of the contingent cultural commodity. The artwork is not merely distributed by the platform; it is repackaged for platform conditions. For a small visual

artist, the product may become a bundle of painting, process reel, caption, personal narrative, and engagement prompt. The artist is rewarded for being both artist and content strategist.

Finding 4: Defensive creativity is the new understanding. The central new understanding of this study is defensive creativity. Defensive creativity is the condition in which artists continue to value authentic expression, but increasingly define and protect that expression in response to algorithmic pressure. It has three parts. The first is protective authenticity: artists insist that likes and reach should not define the value of the work. The second is strategic compliance: artists still use platform tactics because visibility matters for survival. The third is exit imagination: artists imagine websites, email lists, galleries, local networks, and alternative platforms as ways to reduce dependence on algorithmic feeds.

This pattern appears across the corpus. GinAngieLa.com (2024) recommends checking account status and not depending only on Instagram. Saturno (2024b) describes building a website and newsletter as a way to recover control. Hyperlux recommends email lists, websites, real-world connections, and alternative platforms (Kahn, 2025). Leger (n.d.) emphasizes local networking, websites, galleries, and the reminder that likes are not a reflection of artistic worth. These responses are not simple rejection of social media. They are attempts to use social media without allowing it to fully define the artist.

Defensive creativity advances existing research because it shows the identity dimension of algorithmic precarity. Duffy (2020) describes algorithmic precarity as instability produced by opaque and changing platforms. This study supports that idea but adds that small visual artists translate precarity into a defense of artistic selfhood. They ask: Am I making what I believe in, or what the platform will recognize? Am I building an audience, or building value for the platform? Am I an artist, or an unpaid content worker? These questions show that algorithmic

gatekeeping affects not only exposure but also the terms by which artists understand creative integrity.

This also complicates the idea that algorithms simply replace traditional gatekeepers. Algorithms do not operate exactly like gallery owners or critics. They do not usually say yes or no to an artwork in a direct statement. Instead, they create a shifting environment in which artists anticipate what may become visible. The gate is distributed across ranking signals, viewer behavior, platform rules, moderation systems, and monetization incentives. That makes algorithmic gatekeeping harder to confront because the artist cannot appeal to one curator or editor. The artist must keep adjusting to a system that is always partly hidden.

At the same time, the data contains a tension. Some artist-facing texts still present platforms as useful and even necessary. Gallery 4% encourages artists to show process and engage with followers (Ganguly, 2025). Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube present ranking as personalization that helps users find relevant content (Mosseri, 2023; TikTok, 2020; YouTube Help, n.d.). This disconfirming evidence matters because it prevents the conclusion from becoming too simple. The finding is not that artists should leave all platforms. The finding is that platform participation has become emotionally and creatively ambivalent. Artists use the systems that frustrate them because those systems still offer access, discovery, and community.

A closer comparison shows that artists and platforms use different moral vocabularies. Platform documents describe recommendation as personalization, relevance, and user choice. TikTok, for example, explains that recommendations are shaped by interactions and video information (TikTok, 2020), while YouTube frames recommendations as a way to help viewers find videos they may like (YouTube Help, n.d.). Artist-facing texts use a different vocabulary: unfairness, invisibility, pressure, burnout, and survival. The same technical process is therefore narrated in

two incompatible ways. From the platform side, ranking is a service to viewers. From the artist side, ranking is a condition of work. This mismatch is one reason the artist discourse becomes so emotionally intense.

The strongest evidence for defensive creativity appears when the texts move from complaint to boundary-setting. These artists rarely say that visibility is meaningless. Instead, they argue that visibility must be subordinated to artistic control. Leger (n.d.) tells artists that likes and comments are not reflections of the artist or the art. Saturno (2024b) argues for a website and blog where the artist can communicate without the same threat of platform restriction. Hyperlux similarly recommends direct channels and real-world relationships (Kahn, 2025). These are not simply marketing alternatives. They are identity strategies. By building spaces outside the feed, artists try to recover the right to decide how slowly, deeply, or commercially their work should be encountered.

This finding also helps explain why algorithmic pressure can lead to sameness without any platform explicitly ordering artists to copy one another. If artists believe that certain forms are more legible to the ranking system, then many artists may independently move toward those forms: short videos, process reveals, bold thumbnails, personal hooks, trend sounds, and captions designed for engagement. The result is a soft form of standardization. It is not censorship in the direct sense, but it can still narrow creative presentation because artists learn to anticipate what the system is likely to notice. Defensive creativity is therefore both adaptive and risky: it helps artists survive the platform, but it can also make the platform's preferences feel like the natural shape of art online.

Limitations

This study has a few limitations. First, the sample is small and made up of purposefully selected texts. Although the sample is larger than the original study that employed the four-text model, it is still limited to the variety of visual artists that can be represented within this study. Other visual artists from different parts of the world, other languages, other media, or at other stages of their careers may experience these social media text detection algorithms differently. Second, the public essays and posts of advice are rhetorical exercises; the authors may have chosen to focus on their frustrations with social media algorithms or their solutions to those frustrations. Therefore, the study does not analyze the experiences of all visual artists.

Third, the study did not have access to the code of the social media platforms, the authors' analytics software, or the reasons for their public posts. As Kitchin (2017) and Seaver (2017) discuss in their studies of social media and sociotechnical systems, it is difficult to study the algorithms that social media platforms use to curate the content that is published on those platforms. Furthermore, it is impossible to prove that the social media platforms purposefully did not make certain posts by specific visual artists visible to their followers. Fourth, the study was completed by only one researcher. To mitigate this limitation, the coding of the texts was performed twice and with memos from each round of coding.

Implications

The findings of this research have implications for three different communities of practice. For art educators, the findings suggest that social media should not be taught as a means of promoting the art of students within art schools. Instead, educators should consider how to teach students the challenges of social media in relation to the art that they create and how to separate the two values of their art.

For independent artists communities, the findings suggest the importance of sharing information about social media platforms. Independent artists already share information among themselves regarding their social media accounts. However, the findings of this research suggest that such discussions should include topics like ranking of social media accounts, number of followers, visibility of art, and strategies to increase each of these factors.

For the social media platforms themselves, the findings suggest the importance of changing the ways in which they discuss their algorithms. The platforms often describe how their algorithm recommendations may reach the viewers of social media accounts. However, artists need to be provided with the information regarding how their platforms can reach their followers, how they can be recommended to others through the platform, how their accounts may become restricted, and how they can appeal to the social media platforms to correct those restrictions.

Conclusion

This paper discussed the ways in which social media algorithms have an impact upon the creative identity of small independent visual artists. Through a discourse analysis of the texts published by small visual artists and the platforms themselves, it becomes evident that small visual artists describe their social media algorithms as invisible entities that impact their audiences, require them to produce specific types of art, and create feelings of dissatisfaction within themselves.

The finding of the research of this topic is that small visual artists exhibit a form of “defensive creativity” in relation to these algorithms. In other words, they feel a need to protect their creative identity and their authenticity, despite the fact that they often have to change their

behaviors and their type of art in order to survive within their social media platforms. This type of finding is important to both artists and art communities as a means of helping them to understand their challenges within social media platforms.

Beyond the desire to reveal the challenges for artists and the importance of sharing that information within each community of artists, the strongest conclusions of this research is that defensive creativity itself is a topic that should be explored further by both art educators, art communities, and social media platform designers.

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